

What else to watch: *The Pride of the Yankees* (1942) ■ *Mother India* (1957) ■ *Playing Away* (1987) ■ *Salaam Bombay* (1988) ■ *Jodhaa Akbar* (2008)

“He who has **truth and courage** in his heart **shall win** in the end.”

Bhuvan / Lagaan

But this is much more than just an entertaining romp. The movie carries a Gandhian message of redemption and unity, as the fight against the oppressor is undertaken entirely without violence or bitterness. The team's inclusiveness is Gandhian, too: the players include Hindus, a Sikh, a Muslim, and even a *Dalit*, a member of the untouchable caste. Bhuvan has to fight to persuade the other villagers to accept Kachra, the *Dalit*, but Kachra's maimed hand, the physical symbol of his social handicap, turns out to be his trump card, as his misshapen fingers give him a remarkable ability to spin the ball. *Lagaan* is a feel-good movie,

but that is also where its political message lies: feeling good, feeling valued, is essential to healing the wounds that divide people.

Above all, *Lagaan* is a celebration of India. It is a beautiful movie that captures the rich and exuberant colors of the landscape, with its ambers, browns, and yellows. Added to this is the acclaimed soundtrack of A. R. Rahman, that punctuates the movie with captivating songs and music. ■

Bhuvan (Aamir Khan) dances with Gauri (Gracy Singh) as the rest of the village looks on in one of the movie's set-piece musical numbers.

Ashutosh Gowariker Director

Ashutosh Gowariker is renowned for beautifully shot, well-crafted stories. He was born in Mumbai, India, in 1964. After earning a degree in chemistry, he pursued a career in movies as an actor. It wasn't until he was in his 30s that he directed his first movie, *Pehla Nasha* (*First Love*, 1993). His big breakthrough came with *Lagaan*, followed by *Swades*. Romantic comedy *What's Your Raashee?* (2009) was a change of direction, but his period drama *Khelein Hum Jee Jaan Sey*, about the Chittagong uprising, put him back on familiar territory.

Key movies

2001 *Lagaan*

2004 *Swades*

2010 *Khelein Hum Jee Jaan Sey*

